
TRANSITIONS LAB · METHODOLOGY

Measuring What Actually Changed

The Lab's method for field research and impact measurement: Scope, Design, Collect, Deliver, read across Reach, Depth, and Experience.

A practical methodology for anyone who needs evidence of impact that is rigorous, repeatable, and honest about what it can and cannot conclude.

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METHODOLOGY

The difference between output and impact

Most measurement counts what was done. Impact measurement asks what actually changed, for whom, and through what chain of cause and effect. The gap between the two is where most evidence quietly fails.

"Participants reached." "Workshops delivered." "Units sold." These are outputs: easy to count, and they tell you almost nothing about whether a life or an operation actually changed. A programme can report impressive outputs and deliver no impact at all. The reverse is rarer but real: modest activity that changes everything for the people it touches.

This methodology has two halves. The first is a four-step process, Scope, Design, Collect, Deliver, that governs how a study runs. The second is a three-dimensional lens, Reach, Depth, Experience, that governs what a study measures. Together they turn a vague question (did it work?) into a precise, defensible answer.

4

steps from decision to evidence

3

dimensions of real impact

0

impact without a baseline

The people who experience an impact know it best. Our instruments are built around what they say matters, not around what is easiest to count.

THE MEASUREMENT METHOD

THE PROCESS

Scope, Design, Collect, Deliver

The process is deliberately simple. The value is in how well each step is done, and in starting from a decision rather than from data.



Figure 1. The four-step process. Every engagement runs decision-first: Scope establishes the real question before any instrument is built.

01

Scope

Start from the decision, not the data

Every study begins with the decision the client actually faces, not the dataset they imagine they want. We establish the real question, the population that holds the answer, and the evidence that would genuinely change a mind. Most research is wasted here, by gathering data that was never going to settle anything.

02

Design

Build the instrument to fit the question

We design the study to match the question: interviews where depth matters, surveys where comparability matters, baseline-and-endline where change is the claim. This is where technical and social understanding must meet: the instrument has to grasp both the system and the people using it.

03

Collect

Reach the people, properly

Trained researchers who speak the language and know the place reach respondents directly, with informed, recorded consent. In difficult contexts, low-connectivity, multilingual, informal, this step is where most studies quietly fail, and where fieldcraft matters most.

04

Deliver

Evidence you can act on

The client receives clean data, a clear analysis, and a written reading of what it means, benchmarked where possible and honest about limits. Turnaround is measured in weeks. Instruments are built for repetition, so a one-off study becomes a time series.

THE MEASUREMENT LENS

Reach, Depth, Experience

A study measured on one dimension misleads. Count only reach and you learn how many were touched but not whether anything changed. Measure only depth and you miss who was left out. The three together give a complete, honest picture.

Reach.

Who is actually being affected, and, just as important, who is being left out. The easiest dimension to measure and the most often mistaken for the whole story. The critical question is not how many, but who is missing.

Depth.

How materially lives, work, or systems actually change, beyond the headcount. A programme with narrow reach and real depth is often more valuable than one with broad reach and none.

Experience.

What the change feels like to the people inside it, the friction they meet, and the single thing they would fix first. Where a satisfaction score of seven-out-of-ten is unpacked into the actionable truth the number was hiding.

Dimension	The question it answers	How we measure it
Reach	Who is affected, and who is left out?	Surveys, coverage data, sampling
Depth	How materially did things change?	Baseline-endline, magnitude measures
Experience	What does the change feel like?	In-depth interviews, lived-experience data



THE DISCIPLINE THAT DECIDES EVERYTHING

No baseline, no impact

Impact is a change, and a change needs a before. This single discipline separates real impact measurement from after-the-fact assertion, and it is the one most often skipped.

Measurement is too often designed near the end of a project, once there is a report to write. By then the before can only be reconstructed from memory and rounded numbers, which is to say it cannot be reconstructed at all. Without a baseline captured at the start, using the same instrument that will be used at the end, every impact claim rests on assertion.

Capture the baseline first

The before must exist because it was recorded, not because someone remembers it. Same instrument at endline. Data stored and version-controlled. Non-negotiable.

Measure while it is live

Midline readings turn measurement from a post-mortem into a steering instrument, catching what works while there is still time to act. Evidence that arrives after every decision has no value beyond the archive.

KEY POINT

The honesty check

Every Lab study ends with questions most reports skip: did the change happen because of the intervention, or alongside it? What else could explain the result? Who was left out, and does that change the headline? Writing down these answers is the difference between an evaluation and a press release.

A WORKED EXAMPLE

The method applied: a market-expansion study

To show the method in use, consider a manufacturer weighing whether to expand electric two-wheelers into a new region. The four steps and three dimensions turn a broad question into evidence a board can act on.

**WORKED
EXAMPLE**

Should we scale into this market?

Scope. The real decision was not "are riders satisfied" but "does the daily economics work well enough for adoption to hold once the subsidy ends?" We identified the rider segments that would answer it.

Design. A short, repeatable survey on running costs and switching intent (for reach and depth), paired with a smaller set of in-depth rider interviews (for experience). A baseline was captured before any expansion.

Collect. Local researchers who ride the same routes reached riders directly, in their own language, with recorded consent, catching the segments a call-centre survey would have missed.

Deliver. Within weeks: a segmented read on where adoption was real, where it was fragile, and what would have to change to hold it, plus the instrument to run the same measurement again next quarter.

Read across the three dimensions. Reach showed who was adopting and who was priced out; depth showed how much running-cost savings actually moved behaviour; experience surfaced the per-transaction fee riders would fix first, the finding a satisfaction score had hidden.

One question, answered in a way a decision could rest on, and repeatable, so the one-off study became the first point in a trend.

WHY THIS METHOD, AND WHY THE LAB

Rigour, independence, usefulness

This method is built to avoid the two ways impact measurement usually fails: too elaborate to repeat affordably, or too thin to tell you anything you did not already assume. The Lab's standard is the middle ground, structured enough to compare, rich enough to matter.

Independence is the product.

A programme measuring its own impact has every incentive to find success. That is not dishonesty; it is gravity. Independent measurement exists to counter it.

Built for repetition.

Because our instruments are standardised, a single study becomes a trajectory that can be managed, compared, and defended over time.

Written to be used.

Findings are returned in weeks, in language a decision-maker can act on without a translator, tied to the choice in front of them.

Rigour that no one can use has failed at the last step. We write evidence to be acted on.

THE MEASUREMENT METHOD

WORKING WITH TRANSITIONS LAB

From method to measurement

This resource sets out how the Lab measures impact. A live study draws on further method, matched to your decision and the context it sits in.

IN THIS FREE RESOURCE	IN AN ENGAGEMENT, WE GO FURTHER
The four-step process and the reach, depth, experience lens.	› Instruments designed to your decision, with sampling and question design built for your population.
The baseline discipline, explained.	› Baseline, midline, and endline fielded and version-controlled, so change is evidenced, not asserted.
The honesty check, as a principle.	› Formal contribution analysis: what else could explain the result, and who was left out, tested rather than noted.
A worked market-expansion example.	› Benchmarking against comparable studies, so your numbers have a reference point beyond themselves.

The method here is the shape of the work; an engagement is where it is fitted to your question and run in the field.

If a decision in your work turns on evidence of what a technology or programme actually does to real people, we are glad to talk it through, with no obligation. transitionslab.org

Transitions Lab is an independent research team that studies how technologies and programmes meet real people, social science first, technical literacy alongside. This methodology may be used and cited with attribution. transitionslab.org